

8-BALL SCENE

We open looking through the scope of a rifle, trained on a hat with a tall creased crown and wide curved brim. Beneath the brim, a lone android treads forward through a crowd, disappearing for a moment behind a passing freight cart before the reticle finds him again. We pull away from the scope and follow its line up and up, across the open interior of Zakaron and past the beating heat of the Sunlock, until the Overcity resolves on the opposite side of the world and the droid becomes one figure among thousands moving through the streets above. He steps beneath an awning, crosses through a knot of pedestrians waiting beside a transit stop, and ducks into an alleyway tucked away from the crowd.

Another android waits inside beneath the shade of an exposed ventilation duct. His clothes are plain enough to disappear into Kharosai without effort: dark trousers, a weathered coat, a narrow satchel hanging beneath one arm. Two yellow optics turn toward the droid in the hat as he approaches. For several seconds neither speaks; somewhere beyond the alley, a mechanical lift groans upward and a vendor calls after someone who has walked away without their change.

“You’re the contact?”

“That depends who sent you.”

The courier reaches beneath his coat and produces a small metallic disk between two fingers. It is about the width of a large coin but considerably thicker, its pale face surrounded by a darker rim and broken only by a shallow pattern pressed into the surface. The gunslinger looks at it long enough to recognize whatever he needs to recognize, then glances back toward the mouth of the alley.

“That’ll do.”

The courier puts it away. “Where are we going?”

“Not here.”

We cut to the pair moving through Kharosai. They descend a narrow stairwell beneath a row of residential units, pass through a service market crowded with replacement filters and secondhand machine parts, then emerge onto a suspended walkway where the Sunlock catches the edges of passing workers and turns their shadows sharp against the floor. The courier keeps a few paces behind. At one point a municipal drone drops from an overhead rail and scans both of them before continuing on its route without comment.

They eventually leave the heavier foot traffic behind. The buildings here are broader, older, and built more for freight than people, their exterior walls interrupted by loading doors, service ladders, and pipes painted over so many times the warning labels underneath have become raised shapes. The gunslinger stops before a recessed door with no sign over it and presses two fingers against the release. Nothing happens. He waits, presses again, and somewhere inside a lock disengages.

The courier looks at the door, then at him. “Who’s inside?”

“The person we’re here to meet.”

“That isn’t what I asked.”

The gunslinger pushes the door open.

Inside is an old transfer room with most of its original equipment still bolted in place. A loading frame hangs motionless from the ceiling, several cargo restraints sit folded into the floor, and a battered worktable has been pulled beneath the only functioning overhead light. The rest of the room disappears into shadow around it. Someone stands on the other side of the table.

The gunslinger stops just inside. For the first time since the alley, the courier steps up beside him. The figure looks past the gunslinger and toward the courier.

“You brought it?”

The courier does not answer immediately. His yellow optics dart toward the gunslinger, then back to the figure across the room.

“Show them.”

The courier reaches beneath his coat.

The lights cut out.

A violent electrical crack fills the room and our view tears sideways into white static. Something strikes the floor. A gunshot follows, then another from somewhere farther away, and for several seconds the only image we get is interference broken by brief impressions of movement: the edge of the worktable, a body falling, the muzzle flash of a weapon. Then even that disappears.

When the picture returns, it does so slowly. The gunslinger lies on his side near the entrance, one arm folded beneath him and the hat several feet away where it struck the floor. His vision catches and doubles before settling enough to show the courier across the room, collapsed beside the worktable. One side of the courier’s face has been badly damaged.

The figure from across the table kneels beside the courier and reaches beneath his coat, searches once, then reaches farther beneath the fabric. Their hand emerges holding the small metallic disk. They turn it over beneath the overhead light as though checking something on its surface, then close their fingers around it. The courier’s hand shifts against the floor. The figure notices the movement, watches for a moment, then stands.

From behind them, metal scrapes against metal as the gunslinger tries to force himself upright.

“...Annabelle.”

The figure stops and turns around. She looks at the gunslinger on the floor, then toward the open doorway behind him.

“I told you nothing good would come of this.”

The gunslinger manages to get one knee beneath himself before the damaged arm gives way again. He catches himself against the floor and looks past Annabelle toward the courier.

“What did you do?”

Annabelle slips the disk away.

“You had your warning.”

The gunslinger stares at her for another moment.

“You knew I'd come.”

“I thought you might.”

“Then why warn me?”

Annabelle looks back toward the courier, then down at the gunslinger. The weapon is still hanging loosely in one hand.

“I hoped I was wrong.”

She begins walking toward him. The gunslinger watches her approach, looking once toward the courier before returning his attention to Annabelle.

Annabelle stops within arm's reach. The gun rises. The gunslinger's eyes follow it until the barrel settles directly in front of his face. For several seconds neither of them moves.

“Annabelle...”

Bam.